

A serene landscape photograph of a river or lake in autumn. The water is calm, reflecting the surrounding trees and the hazy sky. On the right bank, several birch trees with white bark and yellowing leaves stand prominently. The left bank is covered in dense, dark foliage. In the distance, a small boat is visible on the water. The entire image is overlaid with a semi-transparent orange filter and several large, overlapping circles of varying shades of orange and brown, creating a layered, artistic effect.

LSO 100 – The Canadian Short Story

Week 7 Overview

Week 7: Indigenous Voices and Storytelling

This week, we turn our attention to Indigenous voices and storytelling in Canadian literature through two important contemporary short stories: *"Borders"* by Thomas King and *"Traplines"* by Eden Robinson.

Both stories explore questions of identity, belonging, family, memory, trauma, survival, and cultural continuity. At the same time, they demonstrate how storytelling itself functions within Indigenous literary traditions — not simply as entertainment or narrative structure, but as a way of **preserving knowledge, expressing resistance, maintaining cultural memory, and connecting generations.**

How to Read These Stories

One important point to keep in mind this week is that Indigenous literature should never be reduced to a single experience or perspective. Indigenous writers come from different nations, histories, communities, and cultural traditions. As readers, we must make a fundamental shift in how we engage with these texts.

Thematic Reading

"These stories are about social issues."

- Focusing only on political content
- Reading characters as symbols
- Treating stories as sociological documents
- Searching for a single moral conclusion

Literary Reading ✓

"These stories are carefully crafted literary works."

- Attending to voice, tone, and narration
- Analyzing symbolism and imagery
- Examining characterization and structure
- Interpreting how meaning is made through form

Analytical reading requires paying attention not only to **content** — what the stories are about — but to **form**: the literary techniques and structural choices that shape how meaning is created. Both King and Robinson are skilled literary artists, and their formal decisions deserve the same critical attention as their themes.

"Borders" — Thomas King: Identity Beyond Colonial Categories

At first glance, *"Borders"* appears to tell a very simple story: a mother and her son attempt to cross the border between Canada and the United States in order to visit family. However, the story quickly becomes much more complex when border guards repeatedly ask the mother to declare her citizenship. Instead of identifying herself as either Canadian or American, she answers:

"Blackfoot" (King, 1993).

This moment becomes the emotional and intellectual center of the story. The mother's refusal is significant because the political border separating Canada and the United States was imposed long after Indigenous nations already existed on the land. From her perspective, identifying herself as "Canadian" or "American" would mean accepting categories created by colonial governments rather than by her own people or history.

The Question Raised

Who has the authority to define identity? The story transforms an ordinary bureaucratic situation into a larger philosophical and political question about self-determination and recognition.

The System Exposed

The border guards cannot understand the mother's answer because the system only recognizes limited categories. The story exposes the limits of institutional thinking — officials unable to imagine identity outside state structures.

The Same Answer, Different Meanings

To understand how identity operates in the story, consider what the mother's single repeated answer — "**Blackfoot**" — achieves at different moments in the narrative. The repetition is not simple stubbornness. It is a carefully constructed literary strategy.



A Practical Problem

In the opening moments, the answer appears to be a bureaucratic complication — a woman who cannot or will not provide the required documentation.



A Form of Dignity

As repetition continues, the answer reveals itself as calm, patient resistance. King suggests that dignity itself can become resistance — no speeches required.



A Moral Statement

Eventually, the repeated word becomes a philosophical statement about cultural continuity and self-definition — exposing the weakness of the system simply through its consistency.



A Historical Argument

Ultimately, "Blackfoot" asserts that Indigenous nationhood predates and supersedes the colonial borders that now divide the land. The word carries an entire history within it.

Each encounter with the same answer produces a different interpretive effect for the reader. This is why repetition is an analytical tool in King's story, not merely a plot device. The meaning of the word accumulates across the narrative.

Borders as Symbolic Structures

The title "*Borders*" works on several levels simultaneously. On the literal level, the story concerns the physical border between two countries. However, King also invites readers to think about symbolic and psychological borders that extend far beyond any checkpoint.

Cultural Borders

The division between Indigenous and colonial worldviews — two fundamentally different frameworks for understanding identity, land, and belonging that cannot be reconciled by a single checkbox on a form.

Legal vs. Lived Identity

The gap between how a state defines a person through documents and categories, and how that person understands themselves through history, community, and cultural membership.

Visibility and Erasure

The border station represents institutional authority and surveillance — the attempt to organize human identity into fixed, legible categories. The mother's presence unsettles this system because she does not fit its logic.

The physical border station itself becomes symbolic: a site of institutional authority, surveillance, and the attempt to manage identity. Yet the very fact that the system cannot process the mother's answer reveals a profound limitation. The border does not simply separate two countries. It **reproduces colonial categories** and enforces their authority over human experience.

Storytelling, Oral Tradition, and Cultural Continuity

Near the end of the story, the mother and son wait outside between borders, unable to enter either country. During the night, the mother tells stories connected to the stars and constellations. This moment is one of the most analytically important in the text.

Cultural Survival

While political systems attempt to control movement and identity, storytelling reconnects the characters to something older and more enduring than the border itself.

Historical Continuity

The stories of the stars exist beyond the authority of governments or checkpoints. They carry knowledge that no border guard can confiscate or deny entry to.

Resistance Against Erasure

To tell stories in the space between two borders is to claim that identity cannot be reduced to the categories demanded by either side.

Intergenerational Transmission

Knowledge is transmitted relationally — through memory, voice, listening, and shared experience. The son learns identity not through formal lessons, but through witnessing.

This moment also reminds readers that oral storytelling traditions remain central within many Indigenous cultures. The story does not simply describe this tradition — it **enacts it** by allowing the reader to listen alongside the narrator.

Humor and Irony in King's Narrative

Although "*Borders*" addresses serious themes, King frequently uses humor and irony. This humor is subtle but analytically significant because it destabilizes institutional authority in ways that direct argument cannot.

What the Humor Does

King describes border guards in slightly exaggerated or absurd ways, comparing them to figures from old Western films. Their uniforms, movements, and seriousness begin to appear artificial and performative.

- Reverses traditional power relationships
- Makes the system appear strange and irrational
- Prevents the story from becoming didactic
- Allows irony to expose contradictions naturally

Why It Matters Analytically

Instead of the Indigenous characters appearing "out of place," the border system itself begins to appear strange. This is a significant reversal of the power dynamic readers might expect.

- Humor as a literary strategy, not comic relief
- Irony as a form of political critique
- Tone as a vehicle for meaning
- Reader positioned alongside the narrator's perspective

King's humor also prevents the story from becoming a lecture. Rather than directly telling readers what to think, he allows irony and narrative perspective to expose contradictions naturally. This is why tone must be analyzed as carefully as theme or plot.

The Child Narrator and Perspective

The story is narrated by the mother's son, and this choice is analytically significant. Like framing in visual art, the choice of narrator shapes everything the reader understands about the events being described.

1

Observational Distance

Because the narrator is young, the storytelling voice often feels calm, deceptively simple, and observational. The child describes extraordinary events in an ordinary tone.

2

Dramatic Irony

Readers interpret the political and emotional significance of events even when the narrator describes them casually. The gap between what the narrator understands and what the reader understands is itself meaningful.

3

Learning Through Witnessing

Throughout the story, the son watches his mother carefully. He learns identity not through formal instruction, but through witnessing her actions, dignity, and persistence.

4

Transmission as Theme

The child narrator emphasizes that cultural knowledge passes between generations through experience and story — a structural parallel to the oral storytelling traditions the story depicts.

In "*Borders*," King uses the child's perspective with extraordinary control — the simplicity of the narrating voice does not simplify the story. It **intensifies analytical reading** by making every gap between what is said and what is meant more noticeable.

"Traplines" — Eden Robinson: Family, Violence, and Emotional Survival

While *"Borders"* focuses on nationhood and identity, *"Traplines"* explores family relationships, violence, trauma, vulnerability, and survival within contemporary Indigenous life. The story follows Will, a teenage narrator who becomes increasingly aware of the violence surrounding his cousin, Tom.

1

Restraint

Robinson does not explain everything openly. Readers slowly piece together meaning through gestures, silence, fragmented dialogue, and atmosphere.

2

Accumulation

Tension builds gradually through small details — body language, emotional withdrawal, what characters refuse to say — rather than through direct dramatic confrontation.

3

Recognition

Readers sense danger long before it is openly acknowledged. This replicates the experience of trauma itself, which is often felt as tension and instability rather than clear verbal explanation.

One of Robinson's greatest strengths is restraint. She does not provide easy emotional interpretation. This technique reflects the reality of trauma itself — experienced indirectly, through tension, fear, silence, and instability rather than through complete verbal explanation. As you read, pay close attention to what **is not said** as much as what is.

Silence and Emotional Distance

Silence plays a central role in *"Traplins."* Characters often avoid direct discussion of violence or emotional pain. This silence creates emotional tension throughout the story because readers sense danger long before it is openly acknowledged.

Protection

Silence can shield vulnerable characters from immediate danger. Naming the violence directly may make it more real, more threatening, or more difficult to survive.

Fear

Silence communicates what cannot be safely spoken. The unspoken becomes a presence in itself — something the reader feels even without direct description.

Learned Survival

Characters have learned, through experience, that silence is a strategy for managing environments that are unstable or dangerous. This is not passivity — it is adaptation.

Isolation

Silence can also mark the limits of what community or language can hold. Some experiences are too heavy, too complex, or too frightening to be easily shared.

The emotional power of the story comes partly from what remains unsaid. Readers must interpret pauses, reactions, and absences just as much as spoken dialogue. This makes the reading experience psychologically immersive — readers experience uncertainty alongside the narrator, not from a safe analytical distance.

The Meaning of "Traplines"

The title itself carries symbolic significance. Traditionally, traplines refer to routes used for trapping animals. However, Robinson expands this meaning across several symbolic registers simultaneously.

Literal Traplines

Traditional routes used for trapping animals; connected to Indigenous land use, knowledge, and survival practices rooted in the land.

Emotional Traplines

Patterns of family dysfunction, violence, and trauma that characters are caught within and struggle to escape or survive.

Social Traplines

Systemic constraints — poverty, marginalization, and colonial legacy — that limit characters' choices, mobility, and futures.

Importantly, the title does not simply portray characters as helpless victims. Robinson's characters continue searching for connection, care, and survival despite instability and fear. This complexity prevents the story from becoming simplistic or sentimental — it insists on the full humanity of its characters even within deeply constrained circumstances.

Setting, Atmosphere, and Narrative Voice

Robinson's descriptions create a strong sense of emotional atmosphere. Domestic spaces often feel unstable, tense, or unpredictable. Physical environments mirror psychological states — this is one reason the story feels so emotionally intense.



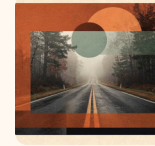
Atmosphere as Meaning

Robinson creates a world where danger is often implied rather than directly announced. Tone, imagery, pacing, and sensory detail carry emotional information that dialogue withholds.



Emotional Realism

Will's first-person narration creates emotional intimacy and instability. Readers experience confusion, fear, loyalty, and uncertainty from inside the narrator's perspective — not as observers, but as participants.



Resisting Closure

The story does not move toward easy resolution because trauma itself rarely resolves neatly. Robinson resists reducing pain into a lesson or moral conclusion — this refusal is itself a meaningful literary choice.

Like King, Robinson uses first-person narration — but to a very different effect. In *"Borders,"* the child narrator creates irony and observational distance. In *"Traplines,"* Will's narration creates emotional immediacy and instability. These are not simply different styles. They are **different formal strategies for producing different kinds of meaning**.

Indigenous Storytelling and the Canadian Short Story

Together, "*Borders*" and "*Traplins*" demonstrate how Indigenous storytelling expands and reshapes the Canadian short story tradition. Neither writer presents characters as stereotypes or symbols. Instead, both King and Robinson create emotionally layered individuals navigating difficult realities.

Centering Indigenous Perspectives

Both stories place Indigenous voices and experiences at the center — not as subjects of outside observation, but as the source of narrative authority and meaning-making.

Challenging National Narratives

King's story directly confronts simplified ideas of Canadian and American identity. Robinson's story makes visible lives and experiences that national narratives often leave unaddressed.

Storytelling as Continuity

In both stories, the act of telling — and the act of listening — connects generations, preserves cultural memory, and sustains identity under pressure from larger systems.

- Both stories also resist easy conclusions. Readers are left with uncertainty, complexity, and unresolved tension. This openness reflects one of the strengths of contemporary Indigenous literature: it asks readers to **listen carefully** rather than search for simplistic answers.

As you move through this week's readings, pay close attention not only to **what happens** in the stories, but also to **how the stories are told**. Voice, form, tone, and structure are not decorative choices — they are the instruments through which meaning is made.

References

Below is a list of key references for this week's readings and contextual study, particularly relevant for LSO 312.

- King, T. (1993). Borders. In *One good story, that one* (pp. 131–148). HarperCollins.
- Robinson, E. (1996). Traplines. In *Traplines* (pp. 3–24). Knopf Canada.
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